

*Oxford  
Poetry*

1918



OXFORD  
BLACKWELL



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Poetry*

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BLACKWELL

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OXFORD POETRY

1918

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# OXFORD POETRY

1918

EDITED BY

T. W. E., E. F. A. G., AND D. L. S.

OXFORD  
B. H. BLACKWELL, BROAD STREET  
1918

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*ANON*  
(*NON-COLL.*)



## BY PROXY

YOU will not lure me with your charms  
Or win me back again  
Because you held me in your arms  
And I forgot my pain.

'Twas not for you my spirit yearned  
That night of fierce desire;  
The flame in which we met and burned  
Drew from an alien fire.

I shall not win my lady's grace,  
Her eyes are still and cold;  
I may not find a resting-place  
Before my life grows old.

One thought alone rejoicing stirs  
And shall, when all is done—  
That in your arms my soul met hers  
And we became as one.

*BASIL BLACKWELL*

(*MERTON*)

## AT THE PAUPER ASYLUM

WITH naked turf-plots three by six in symmetric precision spread  
You see, between its walls of red, the graveyard of the lunatics.

No cenotaph or obelisk holds memory in graven speech;  
Sole epitaph accorded each a number on a painted disk.

In nameless uniformity, with few to know and none to weep,  
While space allows, their freehold keep the men that God has made awry.

And these within their straitened fold, who nothing owned, were owned of  
none,  
Possess of all beneath the Sun what God and man could not withhold.

So close they lie, a skeleton might give his rotting friend a nudge  
And say, "If you or I were judge, we should not moulder here alone.

"Lest we might harm our fellow-men, they prisoned us, and now exhaust,  
To speed a cosmic holocaust, the blood and gold they grudged us then.

"The world had seen less misery with us for prince and presbyter,  
Who sometimes knew the fools we were, and in our folly could not lie.

"But happier we who lived in scorn, and dying, passed from human thought  
Than they whose sophistry has bought the curses of a race unborn."

*C. BURCHARDT*  
(MAGDALEN)

## COMPLAINT

**M**Y love has left me. Let my heart forget  
The happy days and moments of our  
past  
That in the future I shall not regret  
The worship of a love that could not last.

Make me remember there are things apart  
From dreamy love and visionary truth  
And teach me to forget how once my heart  
Did love with all the tenderness of youth.

Yes, teach me to forget—and how to live  
Without the joy of hope. For I have seen  
How every single pleasure life can give  
Must needs sow seeds of misery between.

No more of love. Since at such heavy cost  
It must be bought and even then be lost.

*M. ST. CLARE BYRNE*  
(SOMERVILLE)

**“AND ONE FELL BY THE WAYSIDE ...”**

**S**CHOLAR, and man of letters, and daintily nurtured,  
You were one with your peers,  
Leaving the half-told story,  
Throwing away the dear things of this life-time—  
All you found was the steady, silent effort,  
Only the toilsome moulding, the shaping the weapon,  
None of the keen sword-glory.

Not for you the crown and the consummation,  
Not the battle-death, sharp, swift, and kindly;  
Only the early plodding on, half blindly,  
Only seeing the end by the faith of the spirit,  
Only the hardest of all, the preparation,  
All the heart-breaking spadework,  
Formulas, initiation;  
Only the snows of December ...

Under the snow the quiet brown land lies sleeping,  
Waiting the breath of Spring—  
God will remember.

*J. E. A. CARVER*  
(MAGDALEN)



## EVENING

THE children play, and the old folk talk  
In the silent village square,  
While the wagons jolt, and the belfry's note  
Comes floating through the air.

The white owl hoots from his lofty seat;  
In the fields the rabbits play;  
The weazel squeaks, and the red fox sneaks  
From his lair at close of day.

The final signs of departing day  
Burst out in its changing hues,  
While the stars pearl out in the azure sky,  
And silent fall the dews.

*E. P. CHASE*  
(MAGDALEN)

## ON A BIRTHDAY

AM I a man at last? I feared to think  
Not long ago, that I could ever be  
Older than twenty-one. Eternity  
Is not more vast if one lean o'er its brink  
Than are the cool sane draughts of years we drink  
After the brilliance and the ecstasy  
Of a decisive year. Majority  
We hail; past commoner birthdays we slink.

We love all action that is glorious  
It matters little whether, in our aim  
We seem to fail or are victorious.  
But in the lesser things and lesser hours  
We must—how can we?—spend our treasured powers  
For duties that can never bring us fame.

WILFRED CHILDE  
(MAGDALEN)

## SEA FAIRY

ALL day long the waves wander and the winds cry,  
And there are blue stones sparkling by the shores;  
But with evening there cometh a silence over the void sky  
And the sea is hushed along her coral corridors.

Then the mer-girls fall asleep, their singing is over,  
Their golden limbs lie stretched along the sands;  
And wearily nods the Sun like a giant lover,  
In a blood-red bath of dreams, with lilies in his hands.

On white wings screaming come the elvish gulls  
But lo! where a glint of turquoise divides the cliffs,  
Where the Halcyon Birds whom the rest of the world thinks fools  
Are crossing the Ocean becalmed on their amorous skiffs.

## AGE GOTHIQUE DORÉ

To G. C.

**K**ING Richard in his garden walks royal,  
His mantle green being wrought with scarlet  
flowers,  
His hand holding a coloured book of hours.  
His coat all gold, gilden his feet withal.

King Richard walks in his garden by Thames-side,  
Hearing the bells of high Westminster ring,  
And the sound of the chaunt of the monks echoing,  
Singing each in his stall to God Crucified.

Golden the sun descends beyond Thames-water,  
Golden flash out London steeples and spires,  
Their vanes burn and turn in the day's last fires.

About the King the flowers of the garden fade,  
And in star-light he walks on, yet lonelier,  
His heart being filled with the peace of the Mother Maid.

## ROSA INNOCENS

O YOUNG fresh rose, O tender rose,  
O rose so young, so newly born,  
Whose petals fair do now uncloset  
To the radiant kisses of the air,  
And the shell-soft lips of the morn,  
To the heavens holy and bare!  
Lovely, young, fresh rose,  
Frail-framed and lapped in dew,  
O born like a virgin anew  
After a time of bale and scorn,  
Storm-wind shattering the boughs  
Of the tall trees turn by turn:  
But thou art still abiding  
Amid the slender veins of thy house,  
Like an immaculate lady,  
Very beautiful and causing the eyes of the beholders  
To weep strange tears of joy!

*GERALD H. CROW*  
(*HERTFORD*)

## TRENCH VISION

A GREAT bee potted round the room  
And gossiped like a child to itself,  
Investigating bloom by bloom  
The lilac on the window-shelf.

Outside among the garden beds  
The wind went like a laughing boy,  
And caught the poppies by the heads,  
And chased the honey-bees for joy.

The slanting patch of sunlight crept  
Along the floor, across the wall,  
And I was there and laughed and wept,  
And laughed again to see it all.



## MADHOUSE GARDEN

A LOOF he heareth yet the vulgar urge  
And throng his realm, and groweth glad of bars.  
It is a gentle kingly thaumaturge  
Hath made a net of little silver stars,  
And snared contentment, that great golden carp,  
The moon contentment, that shall never die,  
And charmeth him upon a tender harp,  
And hath him in a net of lazuli.  
Thus I shall hear you crying presently,  
And shall look forth with questioning dream-dimmed eyes  
Upon your turmoil and perplexity,  
Out of whatever hell or paradise  
The maker of nets is come to, bye and bye;  
And shall not understand or sympathize.

*G. D. DESMOND*  
(SOMERVILLE)

## HOME-COMING

COME back to my garment of hills  
Now my soul is laid bare.  
For I gave him my lips and my limbs  
And my hands, and long hair—  
I gave him all things that were mine,  
This my garment of clay.  
So have need of my garment of hills,  
To hide me away—

O high hills, O loved hills, O hills  
That are healing and strength,  
I have grown to your measure at last,  
I can wear you at length.

I have loved, so my soul is upgrown,  
Adult in its nakedness  
And I, as the naked, cry.

\* \* \* \* \*

And the wild, kind hills are my dress.

## AGE

I THINK that I am old. Silent I am with sorrow  
At the beauteous sky that holds the new morrow.  
I think that I am old. The lark sings words to me,  
Who erst sung but Music. And in the ancient sea,  
I can see old colours that I have seen elsewhere....  
Purple orchids hurt me: and everything that's fair—  
Buttercups and distance and smoke, and people's bodies.  
O, I cannot get away from the places where my God is.  
Laughter is a thing to strain and angle for,  
My heart is quick and shrinking and pains me at its core.  
I am older, older, than the Earth—O, I am old.  
If I should be older, colder, than the stars, far off and cold?...  
Once I danced and sang and capered on the grass  
At the cool close of day, when shadows creep and pass.  
When shadows link, and lengthen, and slowly become—nought.  
Light flies, and shadow dies without its sustenance.  
And stars shine out most silently, like jewels quietly wrought.  
Not even then I ceased, nor paused upon my dance.  
Now, I am struck and smitten with beauty's poignancy.  
Now, I am hurt with wonder, closed in from ecstasy.  
No ecstasy is mine. I cannot get away.  
Every way I turn—myself. By night, by day,  
My face, my soul, my body, the people that I know—  
Ah, no more free fashioning of worlds that gleam and go.

\* \* \* \* \*

I have grown to be my own world, my world with heart and pain  
And he that has found himself can be never lost again.  
And he that is quite awake cannot dream his dreams again.

*E. C. DICKINSON*

(NON.-COLL.)

**A TAVERN LILT**

**To W. W.**

I DO not know more wonderful respite  
Than to sit within the Inns of swinkèd lords  
With a mate upon the left hand and the right  
And tankards of good ale upon the boards.

My lads, the World for us when we're in yoke—  
To Hell and through to Heaven twice a day;  
While Lancashire's a splendid land for folk  
Who'd woo a lass or taste a knuckled fray.

And when we're free, with Freedom's cap fast on,  
How shall we bend new lives to jollity?  
What songs our Will and Tom would you have won  
Making the home-thatch rich for you and me?

Our Will, you're young—the lathe you scorn to turn—  
And sorrow life is not all Wigan Fair;  
While I'd seek luck beside a gipsy's burn  
With a brace of whippets for a rabbits snare.

And you, Tom, you—what would you draw for prize?  
A quickened pulse for the lass within your arms—  
With her to walk i' the lanes at the moon's rise,  
By the downland's edge and over the sleeping farms.

My mates, you're English and o' the very best—  
With no mean thought i' the length or breadth o' you:  
Not Galahads, but yet to stand confessed  
With finest hearts as ever heroes knew.

Because o' simple, wide, and proudest worth  
As English soil may give to English rule.  
My head is bared before your richened birth,  
My hand grips yours in cider-time and Yule!

And so again—more wonderful respite  
I know not in the Inns of swinkèd lords,  
With you upon my left hand and my right

with you upon my left hand and my right  
And plenty of good ale upon the boards!

A health, a health, my lads, for very joy!  
With such as you beside for love and life  
We can with ease Dame Sorrowful destroy;  
E'en toast the maid who will not be my wife!

*T. W. EARP*  
(*EXETER*)

## **OUR LADY OF LIGHT**

ON those eternal peaks of thought,  
Where her bright crystal towers  
shine,  
The many precious treasures brought  
Seem its clear walls to incarnadine.

For all the varied colours heaped  
There mingle in one general flush,  
As through that lovely place there leaped  
The rose-leaf burnish of a blush.

The golden arrowheads of wit,  
The laughs of refined sense,  
Diamond of sorrows infinite,  
Calm, open looks of innocence,

And rubies, lovers' burning hearts—  
With these she decks her diadem,  
Transmuting, by her learned arts,  
Each to its own peculiar gem.

The jostling, crowded jewels show  
In sparkling piles where colours dance,  
And with angelic rosy glow  
The ramparts of her palace glance.

And there she busied is, alone,  
To make of beauty beauties fresh,  
Or, seated queenly on her throne,  
Weaves fate into a glittering mesh.

For every soul she gazes through  
And sees its deepest-hid desires,  
As though we were but drops of dew,  
Transparent, lit by alien fires.

This one she chooses; it is clear  
And burns with an intenser flame.



And burns with an intense flame,  
But that, for a long age's year,  
Leaves to the darkness whence it came.

While time itself grows weary, she  
Still solitary sits to weave,  
Until that last eternity  
When all are taken, none to leave.

Then in her magic tissue hapt,  
The new-clothed, fragrant earth shall run  
In visionary radiance wrapped,  
A dazzling sister to the sun,  
And so Our Lady's work be done.

*E. F. A. GEACH*  
(HOME STUDENT)

## ROMANCE

*“J’étais comme un autre Jason allant à la conquête de la toison d’or.”*  
(MADEMOISELLE DE MAUPIN).

ROUND the next corner and in the next street  
Adventure lies in wait for you.  
Oh, who can tell what you may meet  
Round the next corner and in the next street!  
Could life be anything but sweet  
When all is hazardous and new  
Round the next corner and in the next street?  
Adventure lies in wait for you.

## RETROSPECT

NOW I have fallen out of love  
A year or two, I hold review  
Of all the things I used to do,  
Turning with fingers rational  
The closed leaves of my passional.  
And I am quite amazed, by Jove!  
Wholly incredulous I smile—  
So hard it is to reconcile  
With this, my mere immediate me  
The other self I used to be  
You with the you that once was you—  
Now I have fallen out of love  
A year or two.

*E. F. A. GEACH (HOME STUDENT)*  
*D. E. A. WALLACE (SOMERVILLE)*

## **BALLADE OF LADIES WHO DIED FOR LOVE**

LADIES, why did ye all in vain  
Seek death to end your misery?  
Why did ye not forget your pain  
In new loves and new ecstasy?  
Ophelia racked with phantasy,  
And Sigismunda, sick with rue—  
Ladies, why did ye choose to die  
When all the world was made for you?

Wild Phœdra by thy passion slain,  
Cenone, nymph of Thessaly,  
Dido and lily-white Elaine,  
O Queen who died for Antony,  
Sappho and all thy poesy,  
Juliet to thy dead love true—  
Ladies, why did ye choose to die  
When all the world was made for you?

Fair Margaret distraught and fain  
Beside thy phantom love to lie,  
And Isabella who didst wane  
Over thy pot of porphyry,  
Aude and Isolde, tell me why,  
Your lovers direly stricken thro',  
You chose by those same swords to die,  
When all the world was made for you?

ENVOY:

Love's happiness had passed you by,  
But there were other things to do.  
Ladies, why did ye choose to die,  
When all the world was made for you?

*K. GIBBERD*  
(*ST. HILDA'S HALL*)

## WHEN I AM OLD

I OFTEN think that when I'm old and grey,  
Mechanically living through each day,  
That when like all the rest I've found my groove  
With little room for heart or mind to move,  
But just enough to eat and work and dress;  
And keep a failing temper more or less—  
In tired sleep I'll sometimes creep away  
Back down the years to some old Oxford way.

And on this daisied lawn again I'll lie,  
And listen while the river folk go by;  
And through the trees I'll sometimes see the flash  
Of punters' poles and hear the rhythmic splash  
Of oars; and over there again I'll see  
The petalled path beneath the cherry-tree,  
And love the hawthorn scent, the cuckoo's cry,  
And Magdalen chiming while the spring runs by.

And you'll be there, dear phantom friend, and you,  
And you familiar faces that I knew  
So well; and toward the ending of the day  
We'll sit and talk—the old accustomed way,  
Till in the mutual calm we'll see unfurled  
The immeasurable vastness of the world  
And I shall dream of all that I will do  
With Life—and so will you, and you and you.

*RUSSELL GREEN*  
(*QUEEN'S*)

## FAITH

WHEN a foam of snow is hurled  
Under the bare black trees,  
And rain is on the seas,  
And winter on the world,  
Yet, when I think of her,  
I know where summer is.

When friends to-day forget  
Ardours of yesterday,  
And to-morrow turn away  
As if we never met,  
Yet, when I think of her,  
I know where constancy is.

## HILLS

AS I go inland  
Lo! my heart drooping  
As a bird's in the grove when the shadow falls swooping  
Of the hawk's wing down from a cloudless sky.

For the hills creep together,  
Murmuring, conspiring;  
Solitude, poverty, sorrow desiring  
For men that are born to dream and to die.

A prison land-locked,  
A grave for the living,  
And the ancient warders unsleeping, unforgiving,  
Cordon after cordon, massing behind me.  
I am in peril. I have left the sea.

*REGINALD HARRIS*

(C. C. C.)



## SONG

*“My heart was blithe at morning.”*

**M**Y heart was blithe at morning,  
For he was by my side,  
And through the woods together  
We wandered far and wide.

My heart was gay at noon-tide  
Together on the lea  
We lay, and heard the murm’ring  
Of many a busy bee.

My heart was sad at even,  
For in the cold stars’ wake,  
I laid him in the dark, dark grave  
And, oh, my heart would break!

FRAGMENT FROM THE “LAMENT FOR BION,” OF  
MOSCHUS

RAISE high, Sicilian Muses,  
Raise high the mournful cry,  
The mallows in the woodlands  
    Whene’er they fade and die,  
And the dill, and the green parsley,  
    When they grow wan and sere,  
Live on again, though dead a while,  
    And flower another year.

But we, the great, the noble men,  
    The mighty, and the wise,  
Whene’er our term of life is past,  
    And our frail body dies,  
Lie down for ever, evermore  
    Beneath earth’s hollow deep,  
And undisturbed for ever  
    Lie low in death’s long sleep.

MERCY HARVEY  
(*ST. HILDA’S HALL*)

## SONG

O H! who hath seen Twilight the solemn-eyed?  
When the earth with a weary sigh  
Turns unto her, as a widowed bride,  
With the light all gone from the sky.  
She walketh in solitariness,  
Where still, shadowy waters gleam,  
But her grey eyes are none the less  
As if full of a troubled dream.

*H. C. HARWOOD*  
(*BALLIOL*)

## INCOMPATIBILITY

THERE shall be no more sorrow and no more pain.  
Go you to your anger and I to my books again.  
You loved me, but never have liked me, the issue was plain,  
Woman, if you be woman, you live too late,  
Never the man was suckled to be your mate,  
Wed with a god and break him in battle with fate.  
You are truth, and the world is illusion; faith, it is doubt.  
It wraps its disaster in darkness, and you shine out;  
And the liquor that drugs to endurance is not for your drought.  
Pass on to the waste and the fell! I stay, and forget  
Your breasts and your hair and your laughter like suns that are set.  
Despise me, forgive me, but leave me. I love you yet.

## DEDICATION, OF AN UNWRITTEN MASTERPIECE, TO A WOMAN AS YET UNKNOWN

IF I have laboured seven years,  
It was not for your heart.  
Mine was the better part  
And hope is bright amid the vapourous fears.  
You are too close to me to need  
The idle compliment  
That it was my intent  
To build your name above the ages' greed.  
We are comrade adventurers;  
Here is my challenge hurled  
Against the conspired world;  
You will have little time for flatterers,  
An equal combatant ... Or so,  
While in the dark I groped  
Vainly perhaps, I hoped,  
And, when at length we meet and love, shall know.

*LUISA HEWITT*  
(HOME STUDENT)

YOU lit your cigarette from mine,  
And each increased the other's glow  
Till the blue clouds began to blow  
And two red stars began to shine.

Who knows, if then our lips had met,  
A greater fire we might have fanned  
Whose fragrant smoke had filled the land,  
But left us ashes and regret.

## AVE ATQUE VALE

**Z**EUS! whom Prometheus first defied and failed to quell,  
Once, only once I call on you that cannot hear;  
Titans and monstrous Forms inspiring these with fear;  
Heroes enthroned in Heaven, of whom their children tell;  
Pan of the forest, fauns and dryads of the dell;  
Chryselephantine gods to Art and Athens dear,  
Protectors of the deme, the spindle and the spear,—  
Once, only once I give you greeting and—farewell.

Proud-vested charioteers of punctual sun and moon,  
Racing and wrestling in your diverse course divine,  
Ye stars of peace and war, ye rivers of the sea,  
Greeting! from one who will forget your name right soon;  
Farewell! the while I pass, and nevermore repine  
The Perfect God in Man alone constraining me.

*R. M. HEWITT*  
(*KEBLE*)

## ITER PERSICUM

WHEN I rode out of Ispahan  
A thousand years ago,  
My horse's hoofs were shod with gold,  
My turban rolled with gems untold,  
And the people louted low.

My poet rode along with me  
And sang of old Irán,  
Of Rustem and of Rudabeh,  
And whiled away the summer day  
As only poets can.

But now I march the Persian road  
With the devil of a pack;  
The jackals howl as we go by,  
And the fellows sigh and curse and cry,  
And my clothes are like a sack.

And the palaces of Ispahan  
Are full of owls and bats,  
And the truest poet that ever I knew,  
Whose roses grew in the Syrian dew,  
Lies dead at Davos Platz.

## GAUDIUM IN COELO

I DREAMED that I was dead, and after  
My soul had passed its mortal bars  
I caught an echo of rolling laughter  
Across the intervening stars.

And all my fear was changed to wonder,  
I knew the rapture of the blest;  
To hear the immortal sons of thunder  
Applaud each day the immortal jest.

*E. E. ST. L. HILL*

(KEBLE)



## PARTING

THE sky illumed by evening's magic light  
Reflected in the lake seems opal blue.  
The autumn sun glows with a radiance bright  
That gives to everything an orange hue.  
The evening of the year draws on to night.

No sound of arms within this hallowed place  
Comes to disturb us with the thought of strife.  
Unhindered I may gaze upon your face,  
My jewel of priceless worth—my Love—my Life—  
Forgetting I must leave you for a space.

The woods around us, clothed in sombre gold,  
Robed for the great Death Pageant of the year,  
Grow dark. I strain you to my breast and hold  
You there, whispering in your ear  
Stories of love you know ere they are told.

Now I must go. But, when the blue-bells make  
The woods a carpet azure as the sky,  
Once more my darling in my arms I'll take,  
Once more we'll be together—you and I—  
And dream our dreams again and never wake.

*ALDOUS HUXLEY*  
(*BALLIOL*)

## TWO SONGS

### I

**T**HICK-flowered is the trellis  
That hides our joys  
From prying eyes of malice  
And all annoys,  
And we lie rosily bowered.

Through the long afternoons  
And evenings endlessly  
Drawn out, when summer swoons  
In perfume windlessly,  
Sounds our light laughter,

With whispered words between  
And silent kisses.  
None but the flowers have seen  
Our white caresses—  
Flowers and the bright-eyed birds.

### II

MEN of a certain age  
Grow sad  
remembering  
Their youth's libertinage,  
Drinking and chambering.

She, whom devotedly  
Once they solicited,  
Proves all too bloatedly  
Gross when revisited

Twenty years after,  
Sordid years,  
Oh, bitter laughter  
And bitter tears!

## **SONG OF POPLARS**

SHEPHERD, to yon tall poplars tune your flute:  
Let them pierce, keenly, subtly shrill,  
The slow blue rumour of the hill;  
Let the grass cry with an anguish of evening gold,  
And the great sky be mute.

Then hearken how the poplar trees unfold  
Their buds, yet close and gummed and blind,  
In airy leafage of the mind,  
Rustling in silvery whispers the twin-hued scales  
That fade not nor grow old.

“Poplars and fountains and you cypress spires  
Springing in dark and rusty flame,  
Seek you aught that hath a name?  
Or say, say: Are you all an upward agony  
Of undefined desires?

“Say, are you happy in the golden march  
Of sunlight all across the day?  
Or do you watch the uncertain way  
That leads the withering moon on cloudy stairs  
Over the heaven’s wide arch?

“Is it towards sorrow or towards joy you lift  
The sharpness of your trembling spears?  
Or do you seek, through the grey tears  
That blur the sky, in the heart of the triumphing blur,  
A deeper, calmer rift?”

So; I have tuned my music to the trees,  
And there were voices, dim below  
Their shrillness, voices swelling slow  
In the blue murmur of hills, and a golden cry  
And then vast silences.

*C. R. JURY*  
(*MAGDALEN*)

## A SONNET TO A FRIEND

YOUNG bright-plumed eagle, prince of pure heaven's fire,  
Inhabitant of glory clothed in light,  
Exalt me to this new triumphant pyre  
That burns the shades and monsters of our night,  
Vouchsafe thy spirit; touch me with the power  
So to desire, and so maintain my voice  
As thou, who in thy fair ascending hour  
Hawk'st in the top of morning at thy joys;  
O mortal splendour in immortal beams,  
Or deathless ghost, who buildest out of dust  
An edifice of temporal flame which seems  
Beyond the movement of our change and rust,  
Though it must die; O sheer delight above me,  
Fountain of undescended love, I love thee.

## AN EPITAPH

**Y**OU who shall come, exalt these childless dead  
As your great fathers, from whose fire you are  
bred;  
The dead beget you now, for now they give  
Their hope of sons, that you, their sons, may live.

*MARGARET LEIGH*  
(SOMERVILLE)



## TWO EPITAPHS

### I. ON A DIPLOMAT.

O H, who will bid me rise again  
That gambled with the souls of men?  
Those whose lives I signed away  
Will meet me at the Judgment Day,  
My dead: can *they* forgive and pray?  
All honest men, pray for me, and pray well,  
Lest true men's curses send the false to hell.

### II. ON A PROFITEER.

I FATTENED on the blood and tears  
Of these long laborious years;  
Out of loss came forth my gain,  
Watered by another's pain:  
Who shall bid me rise again?  
Pray for me, all poor men, and pray right well,  
Lest poor men's curses bring the rich to hell.

## SONNET: THE JOURNALIST

**H**E called for blood, and would not shed his own,  
He sat at ease, and sent young men to die  
With his strong pen; he was the enemy  
Stalking at noontide, by whose hand were sown  
Rank tares among us—love of country grown  
To poisonous cant, and blind hostility.  
He forged a chain to lead the people by,  
A chain of words, rattling with strident tone.  
He batted on men's selfishness and fear,  
He pulled the strings that shook their statesmen down;  
The people were content to sit and hear  
His platitudes, and tremble at his frown,  
And followed him with meek attentive ear  
Till His Mendacity assumed the crown.

*E. H. W. MEYERSTEIN*  
(MAGDALEN)

## **THE INCANTATION**

E VIL birds of evil feather  
Night and storm are met together,  
Bitter gale and dripping wrack  
Unforetold by almanack.  
Come, Lucasta, bolt the door  
While I grave upon the floor  
Circle wide, and strew around  
Pentacles to guard the ground  
When the solemn fiends appear  
In fulfilment of our prayer;  
For though Cimon scorn thy sight  
He shall sleep with thee to-night.

Wond'rest not how I, a crone  
Whom no crippled lout would own  
His paramour, have strength to fling  
The loveless 'neath his true love's wing.  
The old are strong, the young are fair,  
And thou, wan leaf, whom eager care  
Spirits to this world-shop of mine,  
Shalt for this hour see things divine.  
Thou trustest that my ugliness  
Shall dissipate thy soul's distress.  
Yea, though he loathe Lucasta bright,  
Cimon shall sleep with her to-night.

See yon dun familiar toad  
That infecteth my abode  
With sage humours; stroke his head.  
Now he sleeps as he were dead.  
Yet must he hearken to the charm  
Watching that we take no harm,  
For spirits are fickle as men are  
And called to help may come to war.  
He wakes; now will I cease my croak  
And read the grand words from this book  
That he who recks not of our rite

May sleep with her who loves to-night.

Arise, ye majesties of flame  
Exhorted by Jehovah's name,  
That all things to itself hath won,  
The almighty Tetragrammaton.  
Paymon, Belphegor, ye that err,  
Tried spaniel-friends to Lucifer  
And him whose red and gusty eyes  
Captain the legions of the flies,  
Attend with ceremonious hum,  
Conjure the light o' love to come  
Infirm of step, infirm of sight,  
To sleep with her who loves to-night.

Lucasta, see the lamp burns blue.  
Spirits, have we this boon of you?  
In the smoke their faces nod,  
He shall come though he were God.  
Shake not, girl, thy love they say  
Conquers—Spirits frisk away;  
By the powers that raised you, hence  
To your depths. Ye have licence.  
So, they are vanished. Why so frail?  
Once more the wick gleams yellow pale,  
The smokewreaths whirl to left and right,  
Cimon shall sleep with thee to-night.

He comes; his hand is on the latch,  
The owl shrieks above the thatch,  
Unbolt, unbolt—scatter the yew,  
The tripod, and the cauldron's brew.  
Cimon, Lucasta, hails thee now,  
The star of fate is on his brow,  
His eyes grow moist, his bosom warms,  
Receive him in thy weary arms,  
Loveliest! By Thessalian might  
He sleeps with her he loves to-night.

*ROBERT NICHOLS*  
(*TRINITY*)

**CLOSING LINES FROM “POLYPHEMUS HIS PASSION: A  
PASTORAL”**

THE SHEPHERD. A GIRL.

*Shepherd.* Thus found he his loved Galatea fled  
With Acis! What rage ensued thou knowest.  
Deceived, dejected, foiled, and overthrown  
In hoarse distraction a full sev'n days' term  
He ranged, but on the eighth no more was glimpsed  
Striding from vale to vale nor, raging, heard  
Splintering the pine-slope nigh the precipice  
With fist far flung nor with a desolate  
Thunder of voice, volleyed from scarp to jag,  
Dislodging from steep snowfields friths compact  
In downward avalanche: less loud than he.  
And no tide had we of him, save by chance  
The while I wandered seeking a strayed goat  
Through seaward vales, I happen'd on him.

*Girl.* Ah!  
Lubberly still poor wretch? or quiet grown?

*Shepherd.* He on an ocean pinnacle of rock  
Sat, scowling, motionless. In truth he seemed  
Rather a further buttress of the crag  
Than a giant, helpless and unhappy being.  
About his brooding bulk all day the birds,  
The slippery swallow, the pois'd martin,  
Lifted or swept a-scatter ev'n as when,  
Chatting, such gad around the ravaged mien  
Of the colossal Pharaoh or twin gods  
Hawk-headed and immense of ancient Egypt.  
Thus grieved he. And the huge begnarlèd hands  
Pillared his jaw. A chillness gloomed his face  
As on bare hills shadow of moveless cloud.  
Nor spake he aught. But when the sun raged high  
Grappling a rock he dashed it 'gainst his breast  
And roared till the golden-green sea blackened  
And spouting drove, loud with careering gulls,  
Before his gusty breath; but passion spent  
Dropping then pined, while from the single eye



One tear, as huge and hot as Phlegethon,  
Fell in a hissing flood.

*Girl.* Alas, poor brute!  
And yet I laugh.

*Shepherd.* Longtime in sufferance  
Bowed he his massy head, quite dumb with grief.  
But, at the last, confusedly arousing  
His sluggish hands, groped for and found his pipes  
Twin, dry, boughless trunks of beech fire-hollowed  
And with huge cinder bored. This pair he set  
To cave-like mouth, then, pursing hairy lips,  
Vented, with monster fingers laid on stops,  
His heart's deep sorrow: 'twas a wounding sound.

*Girl.* And was it angry, then, the giant's plaint?

*Shepherd.* Angry 'twas not: though anger in it spake  
As of a rebel turning eye to heav'n  
With moody imprecation natural  
To one so crossed from birth. Melancholy  
Lent majesty to strains uncouth. He mourned  
The gift of might which is his mightiest foe.  
Mourned! though the dire pipes themselves rebelling  
Came apt not to his hand. With rage he shook  
Yet, obstinate, subdued them to his mood  
So that they brimmed the dusky lower air,  
The fire-strewn skies, flushed cliffs and tawny sea  
With the beauty borne of desolation.  
Thus lingered he.

*Girl.*                      And of the tune itself,  
Ugly, was it?

*Shepherd.* Listen: when twilight fell,  
While the near wave lapsed with but seldom foam,  
Darkling against the light foretells the moon,

He still played on. "Strange end," thought I, "thou hast,  
Poor fool whose all of life is ended now,  
Saving the music thou canst make of it."  
Since, as I think, his heart is shipwrecked now:  
Heart, but not song! For as the night waxed late  
Somewhat of beauty found he and with beauty  
Somewhat of solace. To the last I listened  
The while th' unbroken moon rocked in the tide  
And multitudes of sea-sprites, glistening,  
Rose up in choir, but, sudden, hushed to hear  
Such grief pine on. Thus somewhat was the sound—  
Like to the muffled wind among the crags  
When night is clear, without or stars or moon,  
And lightless clouds drift on a lightless sky;  
Or as the mournful blowing of the waves,  
Which in the pylosed gloom of northern cave  
Nightly with flood soon-swallowed and discharge  
Of pouring foam, deep tide and troubled ebb,  
Makes profound plaint and dreary melody  
To lightless waste, huge night and solemn stars.  
Such was the Cyclops' music.

*Girl.* Ah, poor soul!

*Shepherd.* Dost weep?

*Girl.* Yes, shepherd.

*Shepherd.* Fie, now; comfort thee!  
The gods wax angry at a lass's tears  
Who has no whit to cry for. Thus say I,  
Those there are who ev'n by living darken  
The lives of such as are less passionate  
Yet in their fall, by ev'n the full measure  
That they o'ertopped us, must we mourn for them,  
Such wonder has Life bared.

*Girl.* Maybe 'tis so;  
Still I am sorry

But I am sorry.

*Shepherd.* Yield thee now thine arm.  
So: round my neck as mine sinks now round thine....  
Evening falls. Hear the brook in the spinney:  
Thy very voice.

*Girl.* And ... is yon star Venus?

*Shepherd.* Aye: Venus 'tis. Thou hast eyes like heaven.

*Girl.* Love is a pretty thing. Kiss me, sweet shepherd.

*L. RICE-OXLEY*

(*KEBLE*)

## THE OPENING OF THE GRAVE OF ARTHUR AND GUINEVERE AT GLASTONBURY<sup>[A]</sup>

ONE slender relic from the wreck of death,  
One golden hair from that far age,  
A gleaming memory, a momentary breath  
Of mystic times and Merlin sage!

This only trace of that far-famous queen  
And of her beauty causing sin  
Recalled what Lancelot had whilom seen,  
What fame his compeers sought to win.

Swift as a monk stoops down to grasp that hair  
The golden glint dissolves to dust,  
And naught of that old glory lieth there  
But bones, and armour gone to rust.

Seek ye not thus to clutch the golden past  
Of legend and romance, for so  
Its splendour will dissolve and nothing last  
But Now, and dust of long ago.

<sup>[A]</sup> A tradition says that the grave was opened in the time of Henry II., and that all that remained of the royal pair was a hair, which too turned to dust as a monk stooped down to pick it up.

*DOROTHY L. SAYERS*  
(SOMERVILLE)

# **PYGMALION**

Therefore one day, as all flesh must, she died,  
Just as the mowers brought the last load in  
From happy meadows warm with summer-tide,  
And through the open casement, far and thin,  
The nightingale's first music did begin.

"Love is the sum of this world's whole delight,  
Love," said the bird, "the ending of desire,  
Love brought us, timid, forth to the lovely light,  
Love the sole outlet, love, both toil and hire,  
Love, with whose death the songs of life expire."

Yet, as the limbs turned stone and bitter-cold,  
Widowed Pygmalion sat beside the bed,  
Huddling dry-eyed to see the new grown old  
Again so strangely, and his clamorous head  
Jarred him with discourse; and at length he said:

"Marble, my white girl, marble! Cyprian thighs  
And amorous bosom all made chaste once more,  
As though no lips had ever kissed thine eyes  
To slumber—virgin as they were, before  
The feet of Venus glowed along the floor!...

"Thy beauty should have made the workman blind  
That found thee buried in the dust of thrones  
Hereafter, when our pomps are left behind  
Like some strange, sprawling scale of barbarous tones,  
Our temples turned to curious heaps of stones;

"When by the highways merchant folk shall go  
Three feet of earth above our walls and towers,  
And other than Grecian ships bear to and fro  
New wares, new men, and all as brief as flowers—  
Thou hadst outlasted all that time devours.

"But thou art dead; thou art flesh and art dead;  
The grave will be thy lover, thy round breast

The grave will be my lover, my round breast  
Nourish the worm, while, shred by ghastly shred,  
The mouth that laughed, the fingers that caressed,  
Wither, O dearest of my works and best!...

“What have I gained? some mornings when my soul  
Leaped out of me into the arms of day,  
When the world, like a chariot, span in my own control,  
Times when I saw the beech-tree leaves a-sway  
And knew how green they were and far from grey.

“Say I learned joy—this was indeed a gain;  
But can I face the reckoning unafraid?  
For joy I bartered, first, that ancient pain  
Which stabbed me into vision; next, betrayed  
All that men looked for in me; thus I paid.

“Yea, I that rated at a small amount  
That strange, cold jewel, purchased unawares,  
Men’s gratitude—I that no longer count  
For anything in any man’s affairs,  
Am doubtful now; thus the gods grant our prayers.

“Ay me undone! The world cries out to me:  
‘Pygmalion the sculptor, where art thou?’—  
Buried indeed, O buried hopelessly  
Fathom-deep under, fathom-deep under now—  
The curious rootlets pry about his brow ...

“There is no remedy; what is changed is changed;  
No skill can rub out wrinkles from the heart,  
Nor even God knit friends that are estranged  
As innocently again as at the start,  
Since they must keep the memory of that smart

“For good or evil still. So I return  
Never to that old quiet which asked no beat  
Of answering pulse, content alone to burn,  
While no fierce hand might fret thy bosom sweet,

Nor any lover come betwixt thy feet.

“I wrought thee for the world, and then thou wast  
Immortal—and I wept uncomforted;  
But since I made thee mine—O thou art lost  
To me and all men. I was glad,” he said,  
“But thou art dead, O thou art dead, art dead.”

*HELEN SIMPSON*

(*HOME STUDENT*)



## THE HEAD OF THE TABLE; DECODERS W.R.N.S.

EVERY day at ten to three,  
Be the weather wet or  
warm,  
I doff my identity,  
And assume a uniform.  
Clad in this I sally out,  
Cause considerable stir,  
Order nobodies about  
As becomes an Officer;  
Freeze the surreptitious smile  
With a chill severity—  
Longing all the weary while  
For the unregenerate Me.  
But when my release is earned  
And I am at home, secure,  
My identity has turned  
Unexpectedly demure.  
Why? I enter rather late  
And My manner when we meet,  
Seems, I fear, to indicate  
The repentant indiscreet.  
I, thus tantalized by Me  
Spend an irritated day;  
Now the question seems to be—  
What goes on when I'm away?

## AEROPLANE, JUNE 6TH.

I WAS watching as you flew  
Circling in the summer sky;  
Round about you thoughts I threw,  
Every bit as swift as you,  
Every bit as high.

Out of cloud a palace springs,  
Domes and minarets and towers,  
Bastions, where the trumpet rings  
And my topmost turret swings  
High about the showers.

You were captain in the skies  
Nimble as a darting sword—  
Of the company of spies  
Who my castle from surprise  
Vigilantly ward.

Wheeling, darting, unaware  
That you were the warden bold  
Of my palace towering there,  
Of its battlements of air  
And its roofs of gold.

All unheeding trumpet calls  
Down you plunged from out the blue;  
Warderless the silver wells,  
And my airy castle falls  
Swifter far than you.

*L. A. G. STRONG*  
(WADHAM)

## **RUFUS PRAYS**

IN the darkening church,  
Where but a few had stayed,  
At the Litany Desk  
The idiot knelt and prayed.

Rufus, stunted, uncouth.  
The one son of his mother:  
“Eh, I’d sooner ’ave Rufie,”  
She said, “than many another.

“ ’E’s so useful about the ’ouse  
And so gentle as ’e can be:  
And ’e gets up early o’ mornin’s  
To make me a cup o’ tea.”

The formal evensong  
Had passed over his head:  
He sucked his thumb, and squinted,  
And dreamed, instead.

Now while the organ boomed  
To few who still were there,  
At the Litany Desk  
The idiot made his prayer:

“Gawd bless Muther,  
’N’ make Rufie a good lad.  
Take Rufie to Heaven,  
’N’ forgive him when he’s bad.

“ ’N’ early mornin’s in Heaven  
’E’ll make Muther’s tea,  
’N’ a cup for the Lord Jesus  
’N’ a cup for Thee.”

## IN THE GARDEN

A SOFT and flowered vision  
Came on me as a breeze  
In summer, and I saw  
The souls of men like bees.

Up stairs of orchard foam  
With balustrade of may,  
Stagger, a mazy cluster,  
Drunk with the scented day.

Then strong from newer honey,  
With brighter pollen shod,  
The little souls went buzzing  
Up to the Hives of God.

*SHERARD VINES*  
(NEW COLLEGE)

## PERMISSION

NOT till, fallen swooning at the last  
Round, heart-broken at the cruel pace,  
Thrown out useless from my working place  
Sickness, scorn, and bitterness to taste,  
Not till hard days have me crucified  
To a desk, the close nights to a bed  
Comfortless, and all my gain unmade,  
All the towers brought low that were my pride,  
May I seek the silent golden tor,  
Sleep beside long crumbled architraves,  
See the desolate glory of the waves  
Snarling, like tigers on a lone lee shore.

## SUMMER

IN blatant light the grasses look  
Like bronzen swords of green,  
The hillock-tops simmer and smoke,  
The stark road thrusts between.

No mild opacity of cloud  
Transmutes the harshness, where  
Like stars of newly spattered blood  
Kempt cottage flowers stare.

A blast of Hell gets up to flout  
The sharp metallic trees,  
And hungry insects haste about  
Their cruel purposes.

*D. E. A. WALLACE*  
(SOMERVILLE)

## RIVER-POOLS

Were I a shadow in a pool  
I would not live, I would not fear to die;  
But only, faint and cool,  
I'd pass my days of unreality  
In passive contemplation of the sky;  
And no desire should shake me.  
And no denial break me,  
Ah, fool,  
Thou art no shadow in a pool.

Were I a shadow in a pool  
I could not love, I could not thrill with hate;  
But, ashy-pale and cool,  
Through endless meadows moving desolate  
I would outgaze the sky dispassionate,  
With never grief to move me.  
And never friend to love me.  
Glad fool,  
Thou art no shadow in a pool!



## LIFE AND I

LIFE and I are a pair of lovers:  
Life is only as old as I.  
Here he kissed me, with no one by,  
Here the day long will we lie,  
On a hillside swept with the calling of plovers,  
Until the stooping midnight covers  
Life and me with the star-wrought sky.

Life, come kiss me! Joy, come tell me,  
Will you love me still to-morrow?  
Will you ravish me and sell me,  
Love of mine, to sorrow?

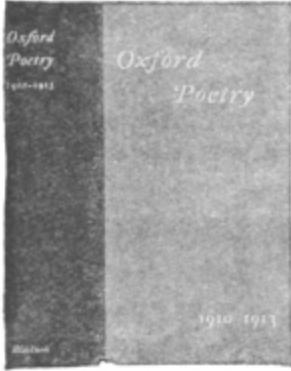
“Sweet, come kiss me! Sweet, come tell me  
No misgivings of the morrow!  
But ... there are two ways to spell me:  
I am Joy—and Sorrow.”

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## FROM B. H. BLACKWELL'S LIST

### **Oxford Poetry, 1910-1913.**



*Out of Print.*

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